SHRI RAM ECONOMICS SUMMIT 2026

Weber Shandwick

SHRI RAM VYAPAAR

Team : WOOKIES

Raunak Jain
Sambhav Khandelwal
Shamit Pratap Singh

Win the right MSMEs first: Turn WhatsApp Business from chat app into a growth workflow

The opportunity is not all 63M MSMEs equally — it is the subset where conversation can most easily become commerce

The real problem is not awareness
it is workflow conversion

Fragmented workflow
Chat here, catalog there, payments elsewhere.

Capability gap
Merchants do not know what to set up first

Trust gap
Authenticity and professional presence are weak

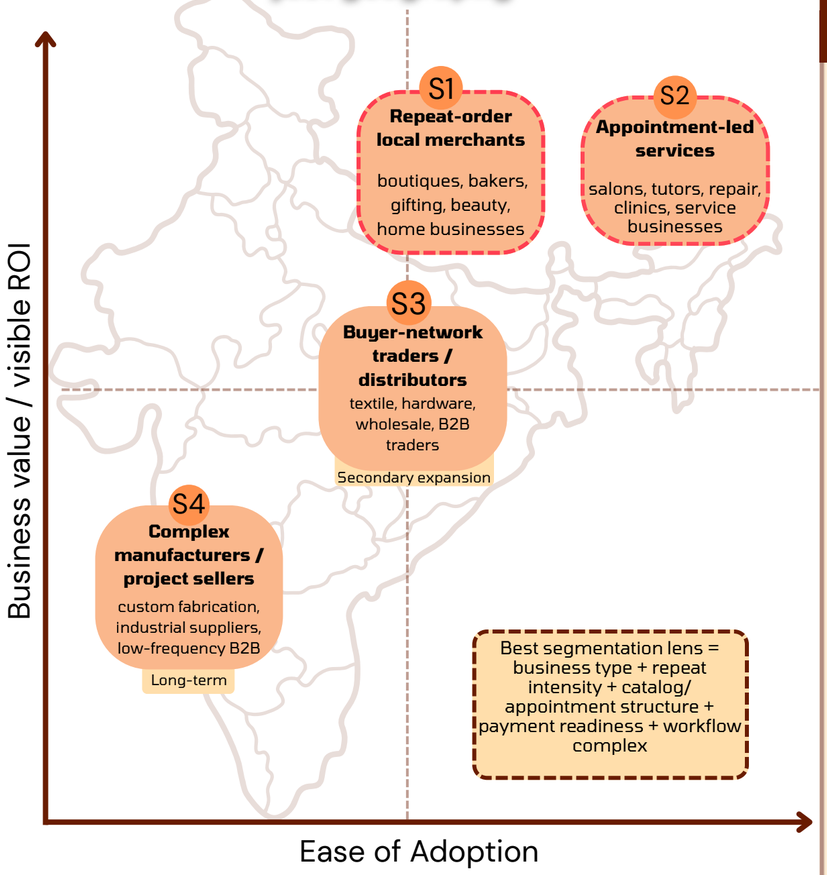
Habit inertia
Manual chatting "works well enough". So no switch.

ROI invisibility
Features feel like admin work unless value appears fast.

Language + literacy barrier
Bharat markets need vernacular, assisted onboarding

Real problem to solve: convert familiar chat behavior into repeatable commerce workflows with first value in days, not months

Prioritize by conversation-to-commerce fit, not just geography



WhatsApp Business should be positioned as a 3-in-1 growth workflow

Storefront
Business Profile + Catalogue

CRM-Lite
Quick Replies + Greeting / Away + Labels

Re-engagement
Broadcast / Customer follow-up

Checkout / closure
Payments / QR / order closure

Lead with response speed + selling clarity; use payments as closure, not the universal opening hero

Hero features for beachhead segments

Quick replies/auto-replies	Highest
Business profile	Foundational
Catalogue	Highest for merchant segments
Labels	CRM-lite backbone
Broadcasts	Medium high once base is set
Payments	Selective hero for services / low-ticket repeat merchants

Do not market WhatsApp Business as another digital tool - make it the easiest way for India's customer-facing MSMEs to look professional, respond faster, and get repeat business on the app they already use

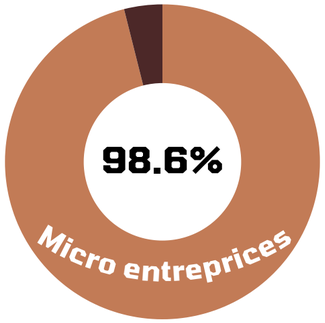
63M+ MSMEs

98.6% Micro entreprices

45% 45% trading | 35% services | 20% manufacturing

886M internet users

55% rural internet share



Adoption wins when the message, feature, and market rollout are sequenced

Segmented communication + guided onboarding + readiness-based expansion can make WhatsApp Business the default growth workflow for India's customer-facing MSMEs

Strategic campaign architecture

S1 Repeat-order local merchants

Core insight: I already sell on chat, but every order is manual and forgotten.
Message: Same WhatsApp, now your digital dukaan
Proof point: profile + catalogue + follow-up + QR make selling look professional and easier
Feature focus: Business Profile, Catalogue, Broadcast, selective Payments
CTA: Set up your catalogue in 10 minutes
Suggested channels → reels, short demo videos, trader associations, merchant creators

S2 Appointment-led services

Core insight: Missed messages = missed bookings
Message: Never lose a booking again
Proof point: quick replies + away/greeting + labels + payments reduce missed demand
Feature focus: Auto-replies, Business Profile, Labels, Payments
CTA: Turn inquiries into confirmed bookings today
Suggested channels → local creators, YouTube shorts, service networks, partner workshops

S3 Buyer-network traders / distributors

Examples: Textile, hardware, electrical, wholesale, B2B traders
Core insight: My team wastes time repeating the same stock and price answers
Message: Your lightweight buyer desk on WhatsApp
Feature focus: Labels + quick replies + broadcast + linked devices improve buyer handling
CTA: Organize buyers and cut response time
Suggested channels → Chambers, trade bodies, accountant/consultant networks, cluster webinars.

Messaging must change by digital literacy, business type, media behavior, and trust source

Vernacular | Peer-led proof | Local associations | Short-form video

Merchant adoption is a staged behavior-change journey - not a one-time awareness campaign

Awareness
- **Barrier:** "Why another version of WhatsApp?"
- **Intervention:** segment-specific vernacular creative with one clear promise
- **KPI:** qualified leads / click-to-WhatsApp rate

Trial
- **Barrier:** Setup feels confusing
- **Intervention:** 3-step starter packs by segment
- **KPI:** Installs / upgrades / onboarding starts

Setup
- **Barrier:** Too many features
- **Intervention**: Forced sequence, start with profile + one hero feature
- **KPI:** Profile completion / first feature activated

First value
- **Barrier:** No clear ROI yet
- **Intervention**: Trigger first campaign / first booking / first payment / first re-engagement
- **KPI:** Time-to-first-value / first transaction / first response improvement

Repeat usage
- **Barrier:** Merchant slips back to manual chat
- **Intervention:** 30-day nudges, weekly tasks, labels, saved replies, catalogue refresh
- **KPI:** Weekly active feature use / 30-day retention

Habit + advocacy
- **Barrier:** No social sharing loop
- **Intervention:** Merchant spotlight, referral, association recognition, peer proof
- **KPI:** Referrals / organic installs / advocacy rate

Scale by readiness: prove ROI first, vernacularize second, institutionalize third

Phase 1 — Beachhead markets (0–6 months)
- **Target markets:** Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Telangana, Delhi NCR
- **Target segments:** S1 + S2
- **Hero actions:** starter packs, short demo creative, QR kits, merchant clinics, Meta education surfaces
- **Hero features:** profile, quick replies, catalogue, selective payments
- **Expected outcome:** fastest POC, high setup completion, first-value case studies

Phase 2 — Expansion markets (6–12 months)
- **Target markets:** Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, West Bengal, Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Bihar
- **Target segments:** S1 + S2 + S3
- **Hero actions:** Assisted vernacular onboarding, cluster workshops, voice/video-led content, trust-led creative
- **Hero features:** Profile, auto-replies, labels, catalogue, broadcast
- **Expected outcome:** Broader adoption in larger but lower-readiness markets

Phase 3 — Ecosystem scale (12–24 months)
- **Target markets:** Dstrict clusters, artisan ecosystems, long-tail India
- **Target segments:** S3 + selected S4
- **Hero actions:** Cluster-led deployment, advanced workflows, linked devices, Integration path, association-led enablement
- **Hero features:** Labels, broadcast, linked devices, integrations
- **Expected outcome:** Institutionalised usage, deeper ecosystem embedding

Zone 1 ~Adoption KPI's

2.2M Activations from priority segments over 24 months

80% Business profile completion

45% Auto-reply / quick-reply adoption

35% Catalogue adoption overall / 45% in merchant segments

35% labels monthly usage

38% broadcast / re-engagement usage

22% payments adoption overall / 30% in appointment -led services

Zone 2 ~Business Outcomes

-40% median first-response time → **+10%** inquiry-to-order / booking conversion uplift → **+12%** repeat purchase / rebooking uplift → **+2–3pp** margin proxy improvement where marketplaces/commission are avoided → **+6pp** direct-order mix in relevant segments → **-25%** manual query-handling time

Zone 3 ~Assumptions/Scenario label

Base case, transparent assumptions
- Based on a priority addressable pool of 8-10M conversation-native MSMEs
- Targets assume guided adoption, not mass untargeted awareness
- Focus is on customer-facing micro businesses where ROI is visible in 7-30 days

SOURCES

Compiled from official government portals, platform documentation, and research publications

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